

# What Will He Be? / The Town Turns

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## CHOSEN: THE STORY BEFORE THE MANGER

### SCENE 9 — “WHAT WILL HE BE?” / THE TOWN TURNS

#### CONTINUOUS FROM SCENE 8

*No traditional blackout.*

*Mary and Joseph are walking home together.*

*The familiar sound of Nazareth begins before the marketplace is fully visible.*

#### HAMMER. BASKET. FABRIC SNAP. CLAP.

*The same work vocabulary from Scene 1.*

*The same stalls. The same baskets. The same fabric. The same people.*

*For a breath, it feels like home.*

*Mary and Joseph enter at the edge of the marketplace, still holding hands.*

*One villager notices.*

*Then another.*

*A conversation slows.*

*A woman stops folding fabric.*

*A merchant looks up.*

*No one has become a villain. They simply know—or think they know.*

*Mary feels the change in the room before anyone says anything.*

*Her hand tightens around Joseph's.*

*Joseph answers with his own.*

*They keep walking.*

## THE CHILDREN BREAK THE TENSION

#### NIA

*Mary!*

*Nia runs toward her before an adult can stop her.*

*Simon follows, more cautiously. Several children trail behind.*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 1**

Nia—

*Too late.*

**NIA**

You're back!

**MARY**

I'm back.

*Simon looks at Mary. Then Joseph. Then Mary again.*

**SIMON**

Is it true?

**VILLAGER WOMAN 2**

Simon!

**SIMON**

What?

**NIA**

You cannot just ask people things like that.

**SIMON**

You were going to ask.

**NIA**

I was going to ask better.

*Mary cannot help a small laugh.*

**MARY**

It's all right.

**NIA**

Are you really having a baby?

*Mary looks briefly at Joseph, then back to the children.*

**MARY**

Yes.

*The children light up immediately.*

*No scandal. No hesitation. Just a baby.*

**CHILD 1**

A boy or a girl?

**MARY**

A boy.

**CHILD 2**

When is he coming?

**SIMON**

Babies do not tell you that.

**NIA**

How do you know?

**SIMON**

Everybody knows that.

**NIA**

You didn't even know where babies—

**SIMON**

Nia!

*A few adults react. Mary covers another laugh. Joseph does too.*

**CHILD 3**

What will he be like?

*Mary pauses.*

**MARY**

I don't know.

**CHILD 3**

You don't?

**MARY**

Not yet.

**SIMON**

Will he be loud?

**NIA**

All babies are loud.

**CHILD 1**

Maybe he'll like stories.

**CHILD 2**

Maybe he'll build things.

*The child looks toward Joseph.*

**CHILD 2**

Like you.

*Joseph is caught off guard—not by the question, but by the future inside it.*

**JOSEPH**

Maybe.

**CHILD 3**

Will you teach him?

*Joseph looks at Mary.*

*This time he does not avoid the answer.*

**JOSEPH**

If he wants to learn, I'll teach him.

**SIMON**

What if he's terrible at it?

**JOSEPH**

Then I'll teach him twice.

*The children laugh.*

*A light musical pulse begins.*

**NIA**

What do you think he'll be?

**"WHAT WILL HE BE?" BEGINS**

**"WHAT WILL HE BE?" — MUSICAL TERRITORY**

*The children lead. Warm, playful, imaginative. The number is entirely about possibility.*

*The adults remain in the marketplace, some working, some watching, some whispering.*

*The song must not explain who Jesus becomes. The audience supplies that knowledge.*

**LYRICAL TERRITORY — NOT FINAL LYRICS**

**INTRO**

**CHILD 3**

*Will he laugh too loud? / Will he sleep all day?*

**CHILD 1**

*Will he race through every market stall / and leave his things in everybody's way?*

**CHILD 2**

*Will he love stories?*

**SIMON**

*Will he climb trees?*

**NIA**

*Will he ask a hundred questions / before anyone can breathe?*

**CHORUS 1**

*What will he be? What will he be?*

*When he is born, for all to see?*

*Will he be different or the same?*

*Will the whole world know his name?*

*What will he be? What will he be?*

*The children imagine ordinary futures: animals, stories, running, helping, learning, teaching, courage, kindness.*

**VERSE 1****CHILD 2**

*Will he build things out of wood?*

**JOSEPH**

*Maybe.*

**CHILD 3**

*Make a chair that's strong and good?*

**JOSEPH**

*I hope.*

**CHILD 1**

*Will you teach him everything?*

*Joseph looks at the child, then at Mary.*

**JOSEPH**

*Everything I know.*

**CHILD 1**

*That's Good!*

**CHILDREN**

*Will he like to run and play?*

*Help a friend along the way?*

*Will he dance and flip about?*

*Will he laugh and scream and shout?*

**CHORUS 2 (Part 1)**

*What will he be? What will he be?*

*When he is born, for all to see?*

*Will he be different or the same?*

*Will the whole world know his name?*

*What will he be? What will he be?*

**CHORUS 2 (Part 2)****CHILDREN**

*What will he be?*

**GOSSIPER 1**

*Whose child is it?*

**CHILDREN**

*What will he be?*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 1**

*Before the wedding.*

**CHILDREN**

*When he is born, for all to see?*

**GOSSIPER 2**

*Does Joseph know?*

**CHILDREN**

*Will he be different or the same?*

*Will the whole world know his name?*

*What will he be?*

**GOSSIPER 4**

*Of course, he knows.*

**CHILDREN**

*What will he be?*

*\*Dance Break: Children Dance\**

**CHORUS 3****CHILDREN**

*What will he be?*

**GOSSIPER 3**

*Then why is he still with her?*

**CHILDREN**

*What will he be?*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 2**

*She says there was an angel.*

**CHILDREN**

*When he is born, for all to see?*

**GOSSIPER 4**

*An Angel?!*

**CHILDREN**

*Will he be different or the same?*

*Will the whole world know his name?*

*What will he be?*

**GOSSIPER 3**

*That's what I heard.*

*Villager 3 looks toward Mary.*

**CHILDREN**

*What will he be?*

**GOSSIPER 4**

*Ay Dios Mio! (eye roll)*

**SONG ENDS**

*The children finish joyfully.*

**CHILDREN**

What will he be? (all together, kids laughing)

*A brief release—then an adult voice.*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 1**

Nia. Come here!

**NIA**

But—

**VILLAGER WOMAN 1**

Now.

*Another adult calls a child away.*

**CHILD 2**

Why?

**VILLAGER WOMAN 2**

Come along.

*One by one, the children are removed from Mary's orbit.*

*Mary watches a child who was laughing beside her moments ago get pulled away.*

*That hurts more than an insult.*

**SIMON**

What happened?

*No adult answers him.*

**THE GOSSIP RHYTHM RETURNS**

*A restrained fragment of "Welcome to Nazareth" lives underneath the dialogue, not celebratory now, but tight and repetitive.*

**GOSSIPER 1**

Before the wedding—

**GOSSIPER 2**

That's what I heard.

**GOSSIPER 3**

Joseph knows.

**GOSSIPER 4**

Ay, everybody knows Joseph knows.

**GOSSIPER 1**

Then why—

**GOSSIPER 2**

Don't ask me.

**GOSSIPER 4**

They say she claims—

**GOSSIPER 3**

God.

*A few villagers react.*

**GOSSIPER 2**

God?

**GOSSIPER 1**

That's what she said.

**GOSSIPER 4**

Convenient.

*In Scene 1, everybody knowing everybody was comedy.*

*Now everybody thinks they know enough.*

**MARY'S FRIENDS**

*Shira moves to Mary immediately.*

**SHIRA**

You all right?

**MARY**

Yes.

*She is not completely all right.*

**SHIRA**

All right.

*Shira stays.*

*Adina joins them, scanning the marketplace.*

**ADINA**

This is getting worse.

**DAFNA**

That is not helpful.

**ADINA**

I'm not trying to be helpful. I'm trying to be accurate.

**DAFNA**

That's Talia's job.

*Talia arrives.*

**TALIA**

What is my job?

**DAFNA**

Being accurate.

**TALIA**

Then Adina is correct.

*Dafna stares at her.*

**DAFNA**

Nobody here understands comfort.

*A small breath of humor. Then—*

**VILLAGER MAN 2**

You believe her?

*The question is aimed at Talia.*

*Talia does not pretend certainty she does not have.*

**TALIA**

I believe Mary told us what happened to her.

**VILLAGER MAN 2**

That is not what I asked.

**TALIA**

I know.

**VILLAGER MAN 2**

So you don't believe it either.

**TALIA**

I didn't say that.

**VILLAGER MAN 2**

Then what are you saying?

*Talia steps slightly closer to Mary.*

**TALIA**

I'm saying you weren't there.

**VILLAGER MAN 2**

Neither were you.

*Talia takes the point.*

**TALIA**

No.

*Beat.*

**TALIA**

Which means neither of us gets to humiliate her over something we did not see.

*Mary looks at her.*

*Talia gives the smallest nod.*

*She stays.*

## **JOSEPH'S FRIENDS**

*Levi, Malachi, Caleb, and Ezra enter or emerge from the marketplace.*

*They see the crowd. Then Joseph. Then Mary holding Joseph's hand.*

*Levi stops.*

**LEVI**

You're really doing this.

**JOSEPH**

Yes.

**LEVI**

After everything you told us?

**JOSEPH**

Yes.

**LEVI**

You believe her?

**JOSEPH**

I do.

*Levi lowers his voice.*

**LEVI**

Then help me understand.

**JOSEPH**

I can't.

*Levi did not expect that.*

**JOSEPH**

Not all of it.

*Beat.*

**JOSEPH**

But I know enough to know she told me the truth.

**LEVI**

I'm trying to protect you.

**JOSEPH**

I know.

**LEVI**

Then let me.

**JOSEPH**

This is me telling you what I chose.

*Levi does not like it. But he hears him.*

**CALEB**

You sure?

**JOSEPH**

I am.

*Caleb nods and moves to Joseph's side.*

**EZRA**

There are still several things about this that make absolutely no sense.

**CALEB**

Ezra.

**EZRA**

There are.

**JOSEPH**

I know.

**EZRA**

And you're comfortable with that?

*Joseph almost smiles at the absurdity.*

**JOSEPH**

No.

*Ezra did not expect that either.*

**JOSEPH**

But understanding everything and knowing what I need to do are not always the same thing.

*Ezra considers it.*

**MALACHI**

That's enough for today.

*Malachi stands beside Joseph.*

*Ezra hesitates, then joins them.*

*Levi remains slightly apart.*

## **THE PUBLIC TEST**

*A Villager Man steps forward. Not a villain. A neighbor who believes he is saying the obvious thing.*

### **VILLAGER MAN**

Joseph. You don't have to do this.

### **JOSEPH**

Do what?

### **VILLAGER MAN**

Carry another man's shame.

*The marketplace quiets.*

*Mary stiffens.*

*Joseph remains controlled.*

### **JOSEPH**

You don't know what you're talking about.

### **VILLAGER MAN**

Everybody knows what happened.

### **JOSEPH**

No.

*Beat.*

### **JOSEPH**

Everybody knows what they heard.

*The Villager Man looks at him.*

### **VILLAGER MAN**

And you're willing to throw away your name for this?

*Levi reacts to the language.*

*Joseph sees it.*

### **JOSEPH**

My name isn't worth much if I have to destroy hers to protect it.

*Silence.*

*The Villager Man turns toward Mary.*

**VILLAGER MAN**

Is what they're saying true?

*Joseph does not step in front of Mary.*

*Mary steps forward herself.*

**MARY**

I told the truth.

**VILLAGER MAN**

About an angel?

**MARY**

Yes.

*Some villagers stare. A few whisper. One or two may laugh under their breath.*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 2**

And you expect all of us to believe that?

*Mary looks around at people she has known all her life.*

**MARY**

No.

*That surprises them.*

**MARY**

I can't make you believe me.

*Beat.*

**MARY**

But I will not call what happened to me a lie just to make you comfortable.

*Silence.*

*This is Mary's public choice.*

**JOSEPH TRIES TO FIX IT**

*The whispers restart.*

**GOSSIPER 2**

Did you hear—

**GOSSIPER 3**

She admitted—

**GOSSIPER 4**

Joseph actually—

**JOSEPH**

Enough!

*Mary gently touches his arm.*

**MARY**

Joseph.

**JOSEPH**

They're talking about you.

**MARY**

I know.

**JOSEPH**

I can explain—

**MARY**

To all of them?

*Joseph looks around.*

*Every face has an opinion.*

**MARY**

You don't have to answer everyone.

**JOSEPH**

I want to.

**MARY**

I know.

*Beat.*

**MARY**

But you can't build your way out of this.

*It lands without cruelty.*

*Joseph looks at the village.*

*For once, he lets the problem remain unsolved.*

**NIA AND SIMON**

*Nia and Simon have watched all of this from nearby.*

**NIA**

Why is everybody angry?

*No one answers.*

**SIMON**

It's still a baby.

*The simple line hangs there.*

**NIA**

We were just singing.

*An adult calls.*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 1**

Nia.

*Nia does not move immediately.*

**VILLAGER WOMAN 1**

Come.

*Nia looks at Mary.*

*Mary gives her a small reassuring smile.*

*Nia goes.*

*Simon follows, looking back once.*

**THE SAME TOWN — DIVIDED**

*The ensemble reorganizes without becoming a cartoon of good people and bad people.*

*Near Mary and Joseph: Shira, Adina, Dafna, Talia, Caleb, Malachi, and Ezra.*

*At a distance: skeptical villagers, whisperers, people who simply do not know what to think.*

*Levi remains between the two groups.*

*Nobody wins the argument.*

*Nazareth does not apologize.*

*The gossip rhythm begins to peak.*

**GOSSIPER 1**

Joseph knows—

**GOSSIPER 2**

Before the wedding—

**GOSSIPER 3**

An angel—

**GOSSIPER 4**

A child—

**GOSSIPER 1**

God—

**GOSSIPER 3**

Can you believe—

## **GOSSIPER 4**

Everybody knows—

**BOOM.**

*A Roman drum cuts through the marketplace.*

*Everything stops.*

**BOOM.**

*A trumpet or unmistakable imperial sound.*

*Rome does not care about Nazareth's scandal.*

## **ROME ENTERS**

*The Roman Announcer enters as though his arrival is unquestionably the most important event of the day.*

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

People of Nazareth!

*A few villagers are still murmuring.*

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

People.

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Of.

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Nazareth.

*The village quiets.*

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Thank you.

*He unrolls the decree.*

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

By decree of Caesar Augustus—

*A villager groans.*

*The Announcer stops and looks directly at them.*

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Your enthusiasm is noted.

### **CALEB**

We haven't even heard it yet.

### **ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

And still you've disappointed Rome.

*A few villagers react.*

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

A census shall be taken. Every household is to be registered according to family line and ancestral city.

*Immediate murmuring.*

**TALIA**

We have to travel?

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

If your ancestral city is elsewhere, yes.

**LEVI**

Who pays for the journey?

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Excellent question.

*Beat.*

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

You do.

*The village groans.*

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

You will present yourself, your household, and the required family information in the appropriate city.

**VILLAGER**

When?

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Immediately.

**CALEB**

Immediately?

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Immediately! It is a wonderful word.

*Beat.*

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

It means now.

*The marketplace explodes into practical anxiety: counting, packing, questions, arguments.*

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Govern yourselves accordingly.

*He begins to roll the decree.*

**ROMAN ANNOUNCER**

Thank yooou.

*He exits as the Roman drum resumes.*

**BETHLEHEM**

*The marketplace is now moving for an entirely different reason.*

*Mary looks at Joseph.*

*He is doing the calculation before she asks.*

**MARY**

Joseph?

*Beat.*

**JOSEPH**

Bethlehem.

*Mary knows what that means: distance, travel, timing.*

**MARY**

When do we leave?

*Joseph looks at her.*

*His first instinct is to protect her.*

**JOSEPH**

Mary—

**MARY**

When?

*He sees that she is not asking whether she is going.*

*She has already decided that.*

*Joseph exhales.*

**JOSEPH**

As soon as we can.

*Mary nods.*

*Their hands find each other again.*

*Around them, Nazareth prepares to move.*

**END SCENE 9**